

THE NEXT 100
ENTERTAINERS

***"I want to be like clay, mould me into anything and I will stick"***

From the hero's friend to other supporting characters, he has now "been testing for a lot more central parts", says Gourav. In the pipeline is a film co-produced by Zoya and Farhan Akhtar, *Kho Gaye Hum Kahan*, and an international series for Apple TV, which also features Meryl Streep. Gourav admits that he's still making sense of the newfound attention. "Sometimes I get a little scared with the confidence people show in me," he says. Gourav credits his small-town upbringing (he was born in Jamshedpur) and his nomadic life in the metropolis (he has moved 12 houses in 14 years) for lending him perspective. A stint at Drama School Mumbai was instrumental in shaping him as an artist. He first made an impression in the independent drama *Rukh* (2017) followed by Sridevi-starrer *Mom* and web series *Hostel Daze*.

With talent agencies in the US and UK now representing him, Gourav has opened himself to work beyond India. "I want to be like clay, mould me into anything and I will stick," he says. ■

**–Suhani Singh**

**RAGA TO RIFFS** A trained Hindustani classical vocalist, Gourav taught himself to play the guitar during the lockdown

# REAL-TIME EMOTIONS

Nimisha Sajayan was 19 when she made her debut in the Dileesh Pothan-directed Malayalam film, *Thondimuthalum Driksakshiyum* (Evidence and the Eyewitness), but it was such an affecting performance that everyone took notice. The next year, in 2018, she won the Kerala State Film Award for Best Actress for her roles in *Oru Kuprasidha Payyan* and *Chola*. The rave reviews have continued in hit movies like *Eeda*, *The Great Indian Kitchen*, *Malik* and *Nayattu* where she held her own against seasoned actors like Fahadh Faasil and others.

**"Nimisha has the ability to transform herself before the camera"**

**MADHUPAL**
*Director, Oru Kuprasiddha Payyan*

Nimisha's parents are from Kerala, but she was born and raised in Mumbai, so it's even more creditable that she has been able to get into the skin of some of her characters. Her first movie came after director Pothan gave a casting call on Facebook. She got the part even though she was a year short of 20 (the director was looking for someone older) and was not fluent in Malayalam. Her latest will be a movie in English, *Footprints on Water*. ■

**– Jeemon Jacob**

**KICK START** Nimisha is a Taekwondo black belt who has represented Maharashtra in competitions